

Oscar Larnce



One of spring's sweetest sounds is wood cracking against horsehide, but that, too, is passing away. Old Dobbin can now go to that Great Pasture in the sky with backsides intact. Bossy has replaced him as baseball cover girl. Big-league teams have made the cowhide pill official. Training camp experiments indicate Bossy may not be as tough as Dobbin. Next, the crack will become a ping as metal replaces ash. College teams are using aluminum bats. They are not so expensive in the long run because they won't break. Six or eight will last a season. Often more wooden bats are broken in a single game.

Opening day is just two weeks away for the Texas Rangers. Their first opponents are the world champion Oakland Raiders at Arlington Stadium April 4, 5 and 6. The Rangers have a new manager and great hopes for a brighter future. They do look a little better but not good enough to be a strong contender. Oakland has the same team as last year and should be in the Series for the third time next October. Houston also is singing praises of its Astros. This is truly their year, they tell you. Like the Rangers, the Orange Crush has a new manager and some new players. Their hopes once more rest upon pitching. Larry Dierker must have a good year if a pennant is to fly in the dome.

Andy Cohen Still Going Strong

Cincinnati still looks like the best in the National League West. The Reds have the pitching and Joe Morgan, Pete Rose, Johnny Bench and Tony Perez. That's enough to put them back in the Series after a two-year absence. Houston and Los Angeles will be their toughest contenders. Yogi Berra's marvelous New York Mets may spring another surprise in the East. They still have the pitching but need a little more hitting.

If you were a baseball fan in the days of the Waco Cubs, you remember Andy Cohen as a great shortstop in the 1925 Texas League team. Old Andy after 46 years is still going strong as baseball coach at the University of Texas at El Paso, where he grew up and was an all-time great high school basketball, football and baseball player. He was all-state on the first state high school basketball championship El Paso team in 1921 and captain and again all-state in 1922, when Lindale won the title but was ruled out because of an ineligible player.

Cohen came to Waco from the University of Alabama, where he earned more fame with his athletic prowess. Manager Del Pratt sold Andy to New York Giants at end of the season for \$20,000. Waco Tribune-Herald sports editor Jinx Tucker wrote one year after becoming a major leaguer, Cohen will more than likely be recognized as the greatest fielding shortstop in the majors. It is doubtful if there is a better fielding shortstop in the big show."

Heyday of Travis Jackson

Andy also was said to be the first Jewish Big League ballplayer in New York, one of the reasons manager John McGraw bought him. Things didn't work out for Andy as expected. Travis Jackson was in his heyday as Giant shortstop. Immortal Frankie Frisch was second baseman so Andy didn't get to play much. He spent 1927 in the minors but came back the next season to play two years as regular second baseman. He batted .274 and .294. His lifetime average for three years was .281.

Cohen played 15 years in the minor leagues, then managed and coached 17 years. We last saw him at Country Campus near Huntsville in 1963, when the Waco Pirates had spring training there. He was the manager of Denver, like Waco a Pittsburgh farm. That was the year the tornado wrecked Katy Park and Waco finished the Big State League season at Longview. Buster Chatham was both business manager and field manager.

Andy is in his 12th year as Miner coach. His record through 1973 was 197-225. Syd, his brother, is assistant coach. He also was a major league pitcher spent more than 25 years in professional baseball. His big league stint was with the Washington Senators. He fanned Babe Ruth for the last time in his American League career and in the same game gave up Babe's final AL home run.

When the University of Texas athletic program is \$250,000 in the red, imagine what shape the poor boys are in . . . John Wooden's UCLA Wonders will win the NCAA basketball title for the eighth straight time by beating North Carolina State at Greensboro, N.C., Saturday. Either Marquette or Kansas then will be their rival in the anticlimactic championship game.